THE RAMBAM'S EIGHT CHAPTERS - SHEMONAH PERAKIM

Why Was Pharaoh Punished If God Hardened His Heart?

The Rambam's Eight Chapters, Chapter 8, Part 2

Sefer: Shemonah Perakim (the Eight Chapters) by the Rambam **Chapter:** Chapter 8 (second part) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Tuesday-night series on the Shemonah Perakim, Tuesday 14 May 2024

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap, and questions on miracles

The class fell on Yom HaAsmaut, and the Rabbi opened by celebrating the fulfilment of the prophets' words that we would return home.

He reviewed last week: people are born with propensities, not with good or bad already fixed; astrology and determinism are false, or the Torah's call to "choose life" would be meaningless. "Everything is in the hands of heaven except the fear of heaven" means nature is in God's hands, our choices are in ours. And for the Rambam, miracles were built into nature at creation, such as the splitting of the sea at Egypt and of the Jordan. He noted that not everyone agrees: the Ramhal held that in a miracle God does change the order of creation.

He then answered questions sent in after the last class.

- **If everything was programmed at creation, is God still involved?** Yes. The discussion was only about supernatural events. Hashem watches what we do, responds to prayer, and there are consequences for our deeds. That is hashgahah pratit, divine providence.
- **How is this different from secular physics?** The secular view is that nature is nature and never changes. The Rambam's view is that God placed within nature the possibility of the supernatural. A fine difference, but a real one.

He added that this is why we do not pray for a miracle, only that Hashem help us within the order of nature.

Standing and sitting, and "like one of us"

When Hazal say a person stands and sits by God's will, the Rambam explains, they mean that God created human beings upright, with hands and fingers, able to stand and sit as they choose. Not that God wills each movement.

The Rambam reads the verse "Man has become like one of us, knowing good and evil" as "one of his own kind": man is unique among species in that he knows good and evil and can

choose. Animals act by instinct; we put down a dangerous animal or a rat because it is a menace, not as a punishment.

Since we have free will, we must train ourselves with habits until they become virtues. In the language of Chapter 2: repeated actions (faculty two) reshape our will (faculty four). "Habits make a person's identity." Never say "I'm an angry person, I'm a stingy person, that's who I am." The Rabbi said this is the whole purpose of Yom Kippur; going through the motions without thinking about who we are misses the point.

A question: if man only gained the knowledge of good and evil after eating from the tree, why was he punished for eating? The Rabbi answered, following Rav Dessler, that Adam always had free choice, or there could be no consequence. Before the sin, evil was outside him, in the form of the serpent. After the sin it entered him, and the choice became far more intense.

The Egyptians: a decree without names

The Rambam now addresses verses that seem to deny free will. First, Hashem told Avraham at the Covenant between the Pieces that his descendants would be enslaved and afflicted. If it was decreed, why were the Egyptians punished?

One answer from the class: they went far beyond what was decreed. The Rabbi said others give this answer, but not the Rambam. The Rambam's answer is that the decree was general. Hashem never said which individual would do it. The Rabbi's analogy: a teacher leaving a class of a hundred says "I know some of you will mess around." The pupil caught playing cannot say "you said so". You chose to be the one.

What if every single Egyptian had refused? The Rabbi said it was theoretically possible but highly unlikely. One participant pointed out that the verse does not name Egypt at all, only "a land not theirs", so another nation would have done it. The Rabbi checked the verse and liked this answer.

He also drew out an implication: the Torah never says every Egyptian died. "Israel saw Egypt dead on the seashore" need not mean every individual, and the plagues need not have struck every person. The Rambam seems to imply that Egyptians who chose not to take part were not punished, though those who could have protested and did not may have shared some responsibility.

The same applies to Hashem telling Moses that the people would stray after other gods, and to every punishment in the Torah. A warning describes what will happen to whoever chooses wrongly. If no one chose wrongly, the warning would simply go unused.

Pharaoh: the Rambam's answer

The hardest case is Pharaoh: "I will harden Pharaoh's heart." If he could not let Israel go, how could he be punished? The Rambam asks us to pay close attention and to compare other answers.

His answer: Pharaoh and his people were not punished for refusing to send Israel out. That would be unjust. They had already sinned of their own free will: "Come, let us deal wisely with them"; the harsh slavery; the plan to throw the boys into the Nile. No one forced them. Their punishment was that the path of teshuvah was closed to them, so that they would bear the

full consequences. Letting Israel go would have been a kind of teshuvah, and that was withheld.

Hashem punishes in different ways: in this world or the next, through the body or through money. Sometimes the punishment is that a person is prevented from acting, like Jeroboam's hand that withered when he ordered the prophet seized, or the men at Lot's door who were struck blind. Do not ask why one punishment and not another, the Rambam says, any more than you ask why the sky is blue.

The Rabbi offered his own way of understanding the psychology. A person chooses a bad habit again and again until he is addicted; he gave the example of a smoker who reaches the point where he cannot refrain on Shabbat. At that moment he may have no free choice, but he is responsible because he led himself there. Pharaoh, in this reading, made himself addicted to evil, and Hashem let that run its course.

Other approaches

- **The Ramban.** Quoting the Rambam's answer, he adds a second: during the first five plagues Pharaoh hardened his own heart. After that, the miracles were so overwhelming that letting Israel go would no longer have been a free choice. Hashem hardened his heart to restore a level playing field. Seforno and Rav Dessler take a similar line.
- **Ibn Ezra.** "In the way a person wishes to go, he is led." Pharaoh chose his path, and Hashem helped him along it. It became harder, but the choice remained.

On these readings Pharaoh kept some freedom. On the Rambam's, he did not.

Why keep sending Moses?

So the Rambam asks himself: if Pharaoh could not let them go, why did Hashem keep sending Moses to ask? His answer: to show the world that when Hashem wishes, He can withhold a person's freedom as a punishment. Any normal person, warned that he would die if he refused, would let them go, as Pharaoh's own servants urged him: "How long will this be a snare to us?" His refusal was a public sign, "so that My name may be declared throughout the earth."

A participant added that the purpose was also for Pharaoh and the nations to recognise God. The Rabbi agreed this is part of it, while the primary point is the punishment for the enslavement.

The next class would take up the great question: if Hashem knows the future, where is our free will?

Summary

- Hashem remains involved in the world through providence; the Rambam's point is that miracles were set into nature at creation.
- Repeated actions become habits, and habits become identity; no one may say "that's just who I am".
- The decree of slavery named no individual, so each Egyptian who oppressed Israel chose to do so.

- For the Rambam, Pharaoh was punished for his earlier free choices; the hardening of his heart was that punishment, closing the way to teshuvah.
- The Ramban (a level playing field) and Ibn Ezra (a person is led on the path he chooses) leave Pharaoh some freedom.

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